

How Much Physical Activity Do Adults Need?

Regular movement supports heart health, mood, sleep, strength, and daily energy. Start from your current level and build up in a way that feels safe and repeatable.

The weekly target

Adults can aim for 150-300 minutes of moderate-intensity activity a week, or 75-150 minutes of vigorous-intensity activity a week. You can also mix moderate and vigorous activity across the week.

MVPA = moderate-to-vigorous physical activity minutes.

Add muscle-strengthening activity on 2+ days each week. This can include bodyweight exercises, resistance bands, carrying groceries, stair climbing, or supervised gym work. Also reduce long sitting by standing, stretching, or walking for a few minutes whenever you have been seated for a long time.

Activity type	What it feels like	Examples
Moderate	Breathing faster but still in control	Brisk walking, cycling on flat ground
Vigorous	Harder breathing and more effort	Jogging, fast cycling, sports drills
Strength	Muscles working against resistance	Squats, wall push-ups, bands

Use the talk test

The talk test is a simple intensity check. During moderate activity, you can talk in short sentences but cannot sing comfortably. During vigorous activity, you can only say a few words before needing to breathe. If you cannot speak at all, slow down.

Steps are a useful everyday proxy

Step counts are not perfect, but they help many people notice patterns. If you are not active now, add a small amount first, such as 500-1,000 extra steps a day for one or two weeks. Over time, many adults can build gradually towards about 7,000-10,000 steps a day, depending on health, work, and mobility.

Do not worry if your step count is lower on some days. Look at the weekly pattern. A day with a brisk 20-minute walk, housework, and stairs still counts as progress.

Make activity fit normal life

Try walking to a further bus stop, taking stairs for one or two floors, doing a short home workout, or joining a community class. Break activity into smaller blocks if that is easier. Ten minutes after meals, three times a day, can be a realistic start.

Key points

- Aim for 150-300 minutes of moderate activity, or 75-150 minutes of vigorous activity, each week.
- Include muscle-strengthening activity on 2+ days each week.
- Use the talk test to check intensity.
- Reduce long sitting with short movement breaks.
- Build steps gradually instead of jumping to a high target overnight.

When to talk to a health professional

Check with a doctor before starting if you have a health condition, chest discomfort, unexplained breathlessness, dizziness, recent surgery, or you are unsure what level is safe.

This guide is sample content written for the LiveWell Coach workshop. It is general information, not medical advice. If you have symptoms or a health condition, speak to a doctor.